

The Celebrity Voice Nobody Paid For: Launching and Killing Shaq on Alexa

Source: real interview transcript, ZipRecruiter product-leader screen, 2026-10-06. Theme: failed product / kill decision with metrics.

The story

Situation. "At Amazon I was on the team that launched celebrity voices for Alexa — pre-LLM era. Mine was Shaquille O'Neal: say 'Hey, Shaq' and the device switched from Alexa's voice to Shaq's. It was a subscription product — \$1.99 a month for Prime members, \$4.99 otherwise."

Task. "The strategy was downstream impact — Alexa's uber-metric. Device owners buy 15 to 20 percent more on Amazon, especially high-margin Amazon devices. The hypothesis: celebrity voices increase time spent with the device, from about 15 minutes a day toward 30. More time means more feature exploration, word of mouth, more device sales — and ultimately more purchases."

Action. "We measured obsessively: DAU and MAU, interactions per day, time in Shaq mode measured from the 'Hey, Shaq' wake word to the last utterance, and domain breadth — were users going horizontal across domains or just doing one trick? When the data came back, I followed it. Only 6 to 7 percent were power users. False-wake rates were far higher than Alexa's own, because the 'Hey, Shaq' model had a fraction of the training data — and false wakes erode trust, which we could see as people unplugging their devices. Free trials didn't convert. We cut the price to 99 cents, which was the sweet spot for conversion, but at 99 cents the royalty economics never worked."

Result. "After three years we shut it down — the math didn't work and it wasn't going to. In hindsight I'd have done two things differently. First, launched as a beta with a controlled experiment instead of a full US launch. Second, structured the business deal in two tiers: launch small alongside Alexa, then re-contract for the big bang — and revenue sharing instead of lump sum. Revenue sharing looks bad long-term, but for an experimental feature it's far better than throwing millions at a contract that assumes 100,000 users from day one."

Interview signal

This is a failure story told with metrics, a kill decision, and a concrete better plan — the three things interviewers look for. The hindsight isn't "we should have tried harder"; it's specific and structural (beta discipline + two-tier deal + revenue sharing). Note the honesty: "Did people pay? No." — said plainly, no defensiveness.

Key takeaways

- Uber-metric framing ("downstream impact") shows you think in business outcomes, not feature outputs. Lead with it whenever the interviewer is metrics-oriented.
- The kill decision is the story's spine — three years of data, then shut it down. Don't rush past it.

- The two-tier deal structure is reusable wisdom: never sign a lump-sum contract on day-one scale assumptions for an experimental product.